PROLOGUE

Robert McNamara could not believe what he had just heard. According to a witness, he “had to hold on to a table to steady himself” after he absorbed the news. It was January 9, 1992, and McNamara, the seventy-five-year-old former secretary of defense under John F. Kennedy and Lyndon B. Johnson, was now in Havana attending a conference on its history, in which he had been a key participant.

In attendance were Fidel Castro and some other prominent participants in the events from the United States, Cuba, and the recently defunct Soviet Union. At the podium was General Anatoly Gribkov, the former commander of the Warsaw Pact military forces and, before that, one of the key planners of the Soviet deployment in Cuba in 1962. What shocked McNamara was Gribkov’s matter-of-fact remark that the Soviets had managed to deploy forty-three thousand men on the island in the summer and fall of 1962. McNamara and his military experts had been sure that there could be no more than ten thousand Soviet troops in Cuba. That was the number on which they were basing their decision whether to strike the Soviet installations and invade the island.

But that was only the first shocking revelation. Gribkov also calmly stated that apart from their huge troop concentration, antiaircraft weapons, bombers, and medium-range missiles capable of striking the United States